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W E D N E S D A Y , J A N U A R Y 2 1 , 2 0 2 6

Healey cites wins; what do the numbers say?

As she seeks another term, governor's record gets a review

By Samantha J. Gross
GLOBE STAFF

Governor Maura Healey officially launched her reelection campaign in a new video with a dig at an old, familiar target, President Trump. But the election will as likely be a refer-

endum on the other issues Healey discussed, including such long-standing challenges as the high cost of housing and energy in Massachusetts.

From lowering the cost of living, to improving schools and turning around an embattled MBTA system, Healey made a number of assertions about her record and delivering on the campaign promises she made four years ago.

One issue likely foremost on the minds of many voters right now is the high cost of heating, with the cold winter weather driving up utility bills. Massachusetts has the third highest electricity rates in the country, and outrage over soaring costs has been building for several years.

Here, Healey boasted of "taking on" utility companies, but so far her efforts are still in early stages.

In October, she sent a two-page

letter to the Department of Public Utilities urging utility regulators to remove any charges on gas and electricity bills that aren't "justified."

While the governor appoints each of the DPU's three commissioners, the department itself operates somewhat independently, which limits the type of changes she can impose beyond pressuring the agency or replacing its leaders. But in De-

HEALEY, Page A6

Sheriffs pad pay through bonuses, incentives

Some pick up thousands of dollars each year; say they're following the rules

By Matt Stout
GLOBE STAFF

Massachusetts county sheriffs' salaries are set by law, increasing only when state legislators say they can. Some have managed to sweeten their paychecks anyway.

Through a mix of "longevity" bonuses, education benefits, and other incentives set by their own offices, many sheriffs have regularly padded their salaries by thousands of dollars a year, a Globe review of payroll records found.

All told, seven current or past sheriffs have collected an average of \$20,000 in "other pay" over the past three years. That's all in addition to their statutory pay, which lawmakers have voted to increase twice in five years, including in 2023, to push most of the 14 sheriffs' annual base salaries to \$191,000.

The elected leaders of their own departments, sheriffs run the local county jails, and wield wide discretion over their multimillion-dollar budgets.

Depending on the department, union and non-union employees alike receive various incentives — and some extend them to the sheriff's post itself.

Hampden County Sheriff Nicholas Cocchi has taken home \$35,000 in extra pay since his second term started in 2023, including a nearly \$10,000 "longevity bonus" last year. Barnstable County's Donna Buckley has earned an additional \$12,528 all three years she's been sheriff — for \$37,580 in

SHERIFFS, Page A7



PHOTOS BY STAN GROSSFELD/GLOBE STAFF

With some help from his mother, Coco Park, Spencer Yang returned to his dorm room at Brown University this week. Below, he spent four days in the emergency room at a New York hospital last month as his wound began to seep blood.

STAN GROSSFELD

‘I thought I was going to die’ in Brown attack

‘I’m the same guy,’ says Spencer Yang, one of the wounded, who is happy to resume school and his life



PROVIDENCE — With a broad smile on his face, but a bullet still lodged in his leg, Spencer Yang returned to Brown University on Monday, 38 days after he was wounded in a mass shooting on campus that killed two fellow students and wounded another eight besides Spencer.

"I think I'm the same guy, just with a little extra metal in me," the freshman from New York quipped.

"Stronger," his father, Jim Yang, quickly rejoined.

Spencer comes from a Brown family. His mother, Coco Park, and his father are both alums, and his sister Yuna is in her junior year and on the volleyball team. The entire family was returning for Providence this week as the kids begin the spring semester.

Spencer Yang said he is appreciating the love from his classmates after he was hit in his left glute in the Dec. 13 shooting. Instead of risking surgery, doctors will let the 9mm bullet work its way to the surface.

Level-headed, with a wry sense of humor, Spencer got laughs when

STUDENT, Page A10

Heavy spending kicks in with interest high on ballot questions

By Matt Stout
GLOBE STAFF

The 2026 election cycle has barely begun, and already the bill for lawmaking at the ballot in Massachusetts is nearing \$10 million.

That's the amount interest groups, unions, and others spent last year trying to get a host of initiatives on the November ballot, from repealing recreational sales of marijuana to lowering the state's income tax to creating friendlier zoning for single-family homes. The total includes \$7.2 million in direct spending, and another \$2.5 million reported as in-kind contributions, such as staff work, according to a slate of new campaign finance filings.

That sum is just a precursor to the eye-popping amounts both supporters and opponents are expected to pour into what could be a record number of ballot initiatives this fall, jockeying for voters' attention when candidates for statewide political office will also be spending heavily to buy advertising space and deploy armies of campaigners.

The dynamic is creating the potential for a record year. The current single-year high for ballot questions is nine, in 1994. Secretary of State William F. Galvin has said 11 have cleared the initial signature hurdle for this year, while an additional

BALLOT, Page A6

►Mixed feelings as students return to class. B1.

An iconic rant about the misuse and overuse of certain words. Is that cringe or not?

By Christopher Muther
GLOBE STAFF

Can an iceberg be iconic? Is the arcade at Dave & Buster's iconic? And is Paris Hilton really an icon?

The answer to all of these questions is a resounding "no." You don't need to hear it from me, but apparently a lot of other people do. CBS News recently called an iceberg iconic. An iceberg can be large, it can be old and cold, but to be iconic, it needs to be "widely known and acknowledged especially for distinctive excellence." That's according to our friends at Merriam-Webster. Tell me, CBS, is that iceberg as well known as a Hermès Birkin bag or Michelangelo's "David"?

I've long seethed at the overuse of the word "iconic." But my kettle really started whistling when I heard a Dave & Buster's



ANDREW PARK/INVISION/ASSOCIATED PRESS

A forthcoming Paris Hilton documentary is called "Infinite Icon: A Visual Memoir."

advertisement calling its arcade iconic. Get the individual who wrote the copy for that ad a dictionary, because I suspect they meant "chaotic" rather than "iconic."

The misuse of the word might possibly be nearing its zenith with the forthcoming Paris Hilton documentary "Infinite Icon: A Visual Memoir," in which the heiress says, "I've had a lot of iconic nights in my life, but this is the most iconic yet." She's referring to herself and her perfume as icons. Because Hilton is an iconic nepobaby and a pioneer of vocal fry, perhaps an exception should be made. Not so much for the perfume.

For years, the United States has experienced an explosion of overhyped iconic moments that are not iconic at all. I once thought I was the only one who chafed

PHRASES, Page A7



Want to step outside

Wednesday: Not as cold.
High 31-36. Low 27-32.

Thursday: Even better.
High 40-45. Low 25-30.

Sunrise: 7:07 Sunset: 4:44

Weather and Comics, G6-7.
Obituaries, C9.

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The Massachusetts Gaming Commission is monitoring the abrupt closure of the Raynham Park simulcasting parlor, one of the state's few gambling facilities that predate casinos. **B5.**

Former WBZ-TV anchor Kate Merrill is asking a federal judge to leave intact key portions of her civil lawsuit against meteorologist Jason Mikell. **B5.**

President Trump and his entourage are making their contempt for Europe clear before a trip there this week. **A3.**

The Time Out Market space might as well go full Boston, writes Devra First, who has some — ahem — ideas. **G1.**

The loss of quarterback Bo Nix changed everything for the Broncos as they prepare to face the Patriots on Sunday. **C1.**